began ushering in a series of reforms known as *Glasnost* (openness) and *Perestroika* (restructuring) to imagine a new, more economical form of Soviet communism.[79] Against controversy surrounding nefarious aspects of rollback, the U.S. Congress passed new iterations of the existing Boland Amendments to ban funding of Nicaraguan contras, as Reagan's CIA continued to funnel money to the guerrilla forces through illegal arms sales, later uncovered in the Iran Contra scandal.

Divided Berlin did not disappear entirely from Cold War consciousness in the United States, as the city continued its role as an integral military and cultural hub. Earlier in 1986, a West Berlin disco in the neighborhood of Schöneberg that was popular with American GIs was bombed at the behest of the Libyan government. The violent act killed two servicemen and one Turkish woman, and the United States responded by bombing Libya.[80] The following year, in June 1987, Reagan returned to Germany, this time to West Berlin as a speaker for the city's 750th anniversary celebration. On this trip he spoke in the British-occupied sector, within steps of the Brandenburg Gate. There, Reagan uttered some of the most memorable words of his presidency: "Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall." Reagan spoke on a stage within close proximity to the Berlin Wall, flanked by a backdrop of American and West German flags and a bulletproof, transparent window open to the Wall and Brandenburg Gate behind him. During Reagan's visit, thousands of West Germans also went to the streets to loudly protest his appearance, which occurred days after a series of homegrown May Day riots in Kreuzberg.[81] In addition to foreshadowing the ultimate thaw of the Cold War, the Reagan visit marked a "theatrical turn," as Ted Widmer suggests, in which "Reagan's inner actor proved shrewder than most who would have counseled realpolitik."[82] Cultural productions of the period continued to imagine ways to deal with the shifting geopolitical dynamics of Cold War Berlin.[83]

For Lorde, *Our Dead Behind Us* showcased for readers her approach to the ideas of diaspora and difference brought out through her travels to Europe, with an eye on related global sites of repression. Reviewers remarked on her geographic fluidity, though they varied in their views of the interrelatedness of her sites of poetry and the political approaches of her work. TLS's Alice Phillips notes, "Lord [*sic*] travels instead to Grenada (at least in imagination), Berlin, Florida, Tashkent, reporting on old atrocities and new outbreaks of oppression, and returns to her racially unsettled